The Zionist Camp had promised to renew negotiations with the Palestinians. In that sense, it did offer a contrast with Netanyahu. But Herzog himself did not seem to think the negotiations would succeed. “I don’t want to build expectations,” he said at a campaign stop. He vowed that Jerusalem “must remain united as Israel’s capital,” and promised not to concede the Jordan Valley, both deal-breakers for the Palestinians. His nebulous peace plan envisioned at least five years of talks—longer than the term of an Israeli government. The Oslo Accords, which were meant to be a five-year interim measure, had recently turned twenty-one. Herzog’s plan was to create another five-year plan. The differences between Netanyahu and Herzog, as the journalist Barak Ravid summarized in a column for *Ha’aretz*, were more style than substance.

A month before the rally, a few hundred people had packed into a hangar at Tel Aviv’s old port for a debate on foreign policy and security issues. It had covered the breadth of Israel’s main Zionist parties, from Meretz to Jewish Home. It was also conducted in English—a hint as to the intended audience.

Michael Oren, Israel’s former ambassador to Washington and a candidate with the centrist Kulanu party, told the audience it might take “two or three generations for a Palestinian leader to emerge and sign a deal with us.” Hilik Bar, the Labor party’s secretary-general, joked about a recent trip to Northern Ireland. “They told us it took 700 years to resolve their conflict,” he said.

This accounts to some degree for the 25 per cent of Israeli Jews who want to talk for the sake of talking. The peace process has not brought peace, but the process itself pays dividends, helping to shield Israel from international criticism. “We have to be convincing when we say we have no desire to continue ruling over 2.5 million Palestinians,” Oren said. It has similar psychological benefits for Israeli voters, replacing the prospect of permanent occupation with one of indeterminate negotiations. Practically speaking, the two are the same, but the latter is easier to stomach.

“This is not a parameter that differentiates between the parties, because Israelis understand that whoever is prime minister, nothing will change with the Palestinians,” said Dani Dayan, the former director of the Yesha Council, the main settler lobby group.

There is similarly little daylight between them on other security issues. Netanyahu’s opponents panned his controversial Iran speech in Washington,